

Rukmini Banerji

Dr. Rukmini Banerji is Senior Advisor and former CEO (2015–2026) of Pratham Education Foundation, one of India's largest education non-profits. With Pratham since 1996, she led the Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) and helped turn Teaching at the Right Level into an approach used by governments across India and Africa.

Education

- BA in Economics, St. Stephen's College; studied at the Delhi School of Economics
- Rhodes Scholar, University of Oxford (1981–83)
- PhD, University of Chicago (1991); postdoctoral work at its Population Research Center

Career

Worked as a programme officer at the Spencer Foundation in Chicago before returning to India in 1996 to join Pratham's national leadership team. Worked extensively on Pratham's programmes in rural and urban areas and was responsible for its work in major north Indian states such as Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.

Led Pratham's research and assessment work, including ASER from its launch in 2005 to 2014, and served as Director of the ASER Centre, Pratham's autonomous research and assessment unit, for about ten years.

Became CEO in 2015 and led Pratham for over a decade, designing large-scale partnerships with state governments to improve children's learning. In 2023 Pratham launched the Pratham–Jameel Second Chance programme with Community Jameel, supporting 10,000 girls who had dropped out of school to complete grade 10. Handed over the CEO role in 2026 and continues as Senior Advisor.

Awards and Recognition

- Yidan Prize for Education Development (2021)
- Maulana Abul Kalam Shiksha Puraskar, Government of Bihar (2008), as its first recipient
- Rhodes Scholar, University of Oxford (1981–83)
- Member, Central Advisory Board of Education (CABE) committee, and of the RISE Programme's Intellectual Leadership Team
- Member of the Hewlett Foundation's advisory group on quality of education; has represented Pratham and the ASER Centre at national and international forums
- Writes regularly on education in Hindi and English dailies, and writes books and stories for children



Rukmini Banerji's Story

Originally from Bihar and trained as an economist, Rukmini's path changed while volunteering in a Chicago public school during her PhD. The experience pulled her toward grassroots work and, eventually, back to India and Pratham. For three decades since, one question has shaped her work: why are so many Indian children in school but not learning?

Leadership at Pratham

Rukmini helped grow Pratham from early experiments in a single Mumbai slum into an organisation working across 26 states and 16 countries. ASER became a citizen-led, nationwide household survey of children's learning, and Teaching at the Right Level is now used by state governments across India and in several African countries.

She argues for keeping ideas simple enough that anyone can take part, and for letting communities discover problems for themselves rather than simply being shown data. She pairs rigorous data with grounded, community-rooted work, and curiosity with a healthy dose of skepticism.

Pratham's leadership brings together people who rose from the field with professionals from elsewhere. Its culture of trust has produced many alumni who went on to found their own organisations.

She speaks candidly about shifts in funding, about building leadership pipelines from the ground up, and about her own handover of the CEO role.

Her advice to newcomers: spend real time on the ground first, and join only if you sense there is a great deal left to learn.